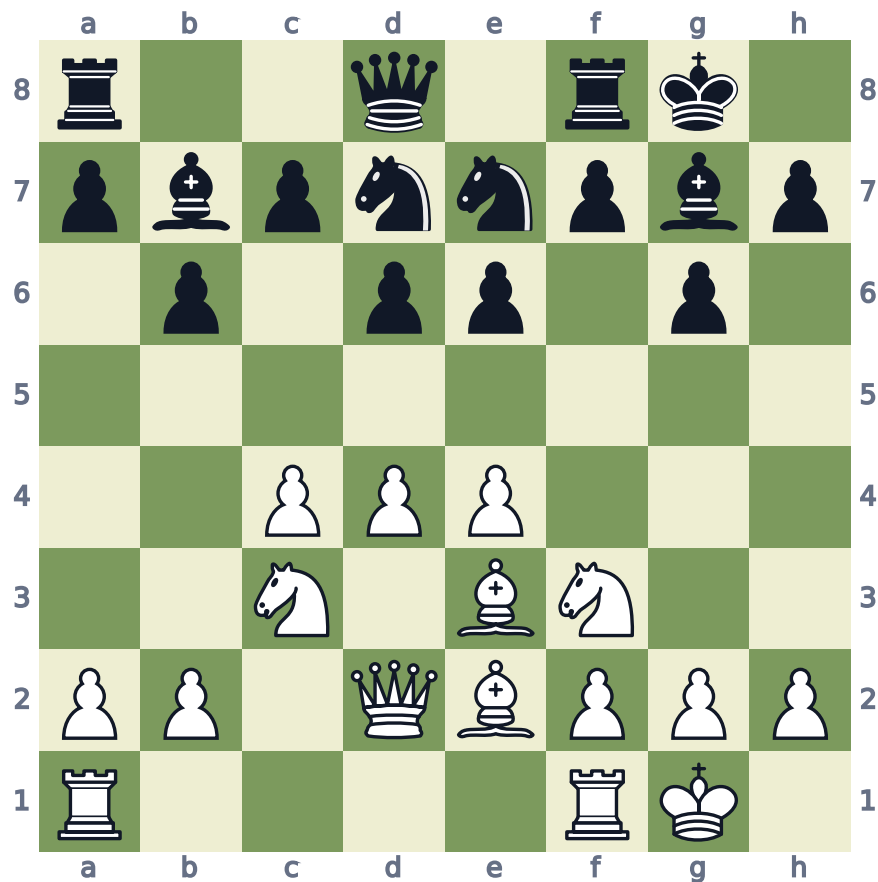


Hippo vs 1.d4: Queen's Pawn Centers

Classical centers, London and Colle shells, Catalan diagonals, and Stonewall space



Use the Hippo against Queen's Pawn systems without confusing similar-looking setups or allowing a slow squeeze without a freeing break.

8 learning units | solid-piece diagrams | recall tests | engine checks

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Use the Hippo against Queen's Pawn systems without confusing similar-looking setups or allowing a slow squeeze without a freeing break.

THE HIPPO TRAINING LOOP

- First identify the center, both kings, and the opponent's most forcing pawn break.
- At every diagram, name the urgent threat and compare e5, c5, f5, and b5.
- Hide the answer until you have spoken the move, its purpose, and the opponent's best reply.
- Replay each branch from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected Black core repertoire. It teaches setup, exceptions, transformation, and resulting plans; the PGN companions make later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

c4 and e4 create the largest center and usually demand c5 or e5.

PRINCIPLE 2

Against the London, Black should challenge the center rather than chase the bishop automatically.

PRINCIPLE 3

Colle setups are slower, giving Black time to improve the shell before breaking.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

Catalan pressure on the long diagonal makes queenside timing concrete.

PRINCIPLE 5

Stonewall pawns weaken dark squares even while gaining kingside space.

PRINCIPLE 6

A closed center gives maneuvering time only until one side can open a favorable file.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

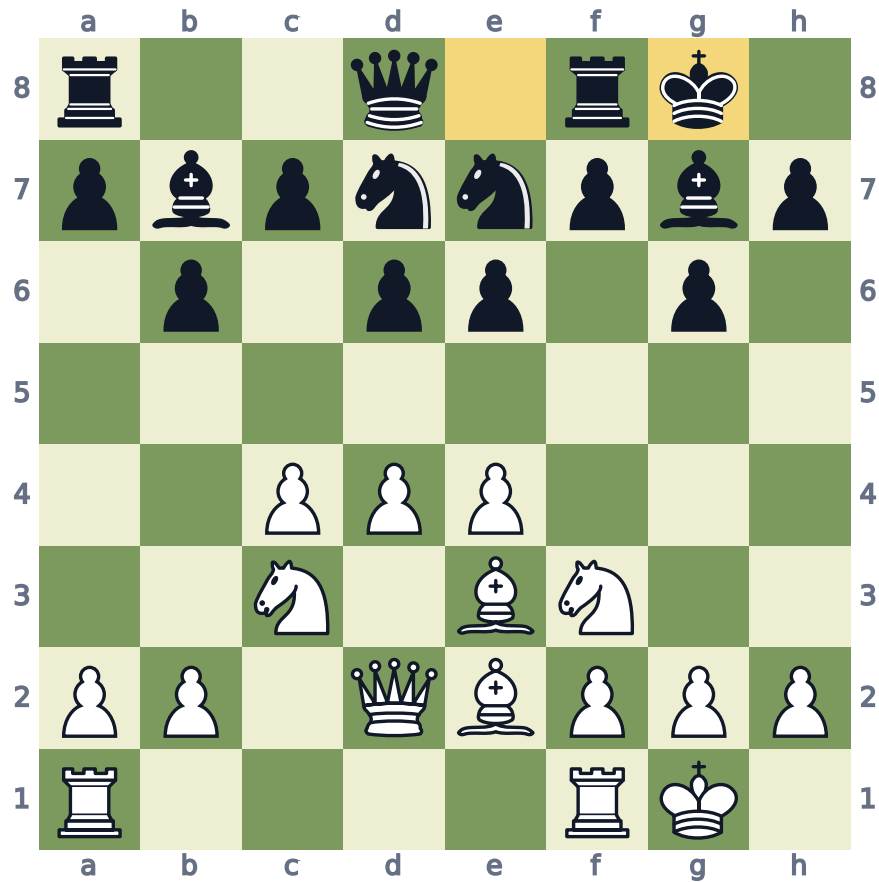
- | | | |
|-----------|--------------------------------------|---|
| 01 | Classical Queen's Pawn center | Against c4-d4-e4, attack the base before White fixes it. |
| 02 | London System | The London bishop is not the center; challenge d4 and e4. |
| 03 | Colle System | Extra setup time is a resource only when it is invested in a break. |
| 04 | Torre bishop on g5 | Do not spend time attacking Bg5 unless the gain helps the central break. |
| 05 | Jobava-style Nc3 and Bf4 | Nc3 plus long castling makes move order tactical; counter in the center and queenside. |
| 06 | Catalan fianchetto | In a double fianchetto, the pawn break decides which bishop is real. |
| 07 | Trompowsky-style Bg5 | White's e3 protects d4; now Black can build the shell without overlooking a loose pawn. |
| 08 | Stonewall formation | The Stonewall gains space and permanently concedes e4; make that square useful. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

Classical Queen's Pawn center



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 Nd7 7. O-O b6 8. Be3 Bb7 9. Qd2 O-O

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

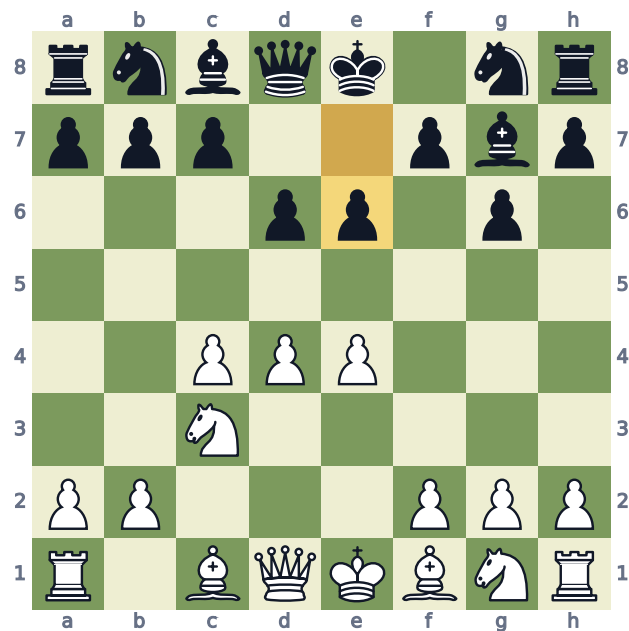
Complete the shell and prepare c5 or e5 against the broad center.

MAIN DANGER

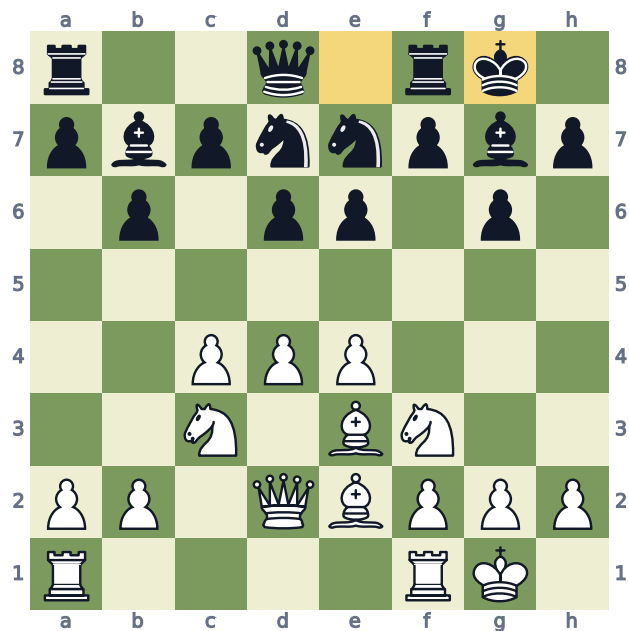
d5 can gain space and restrict both knights.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against c4-d4-e4, attack the base before White fixes it.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.06 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Rad1 Nf6 2. d5 e5 3. Ne1 Bc8

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

Classical Queen's Pawn center



YOUR TASK

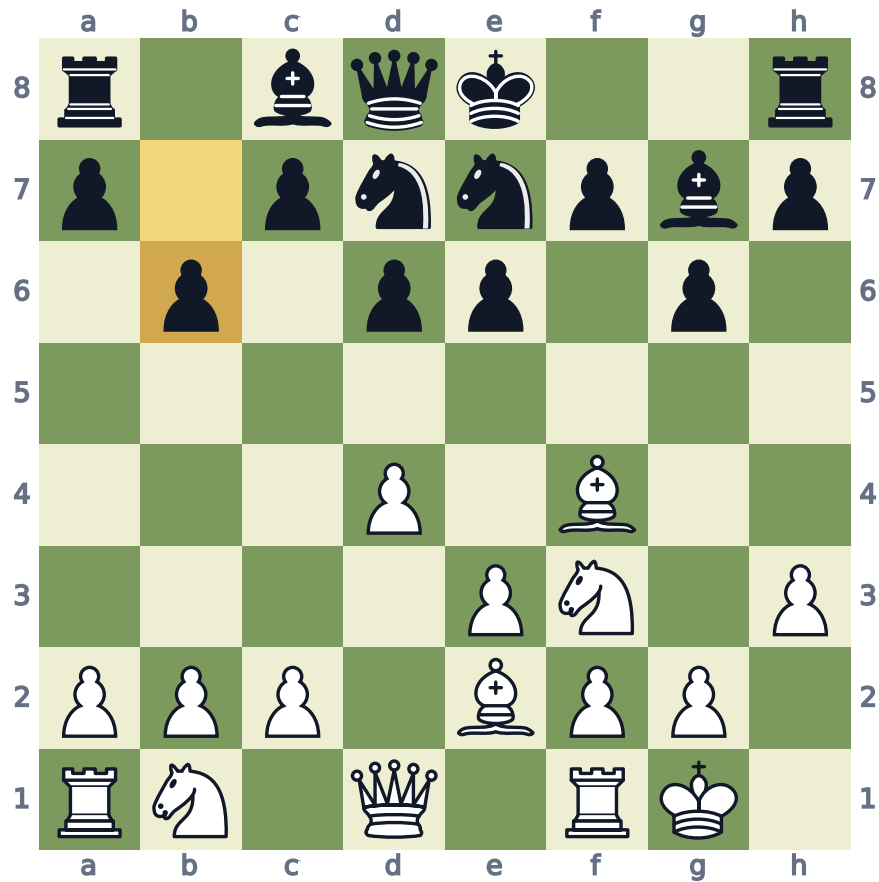
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

London System



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. Bf4 d6 4. e3 e6 5. h3 Ne7 6. Be2 Nd7 7. O-O b6

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Develop without chasing Bf4 and prepare e5 or c5 against d4.

MAIN DANGER

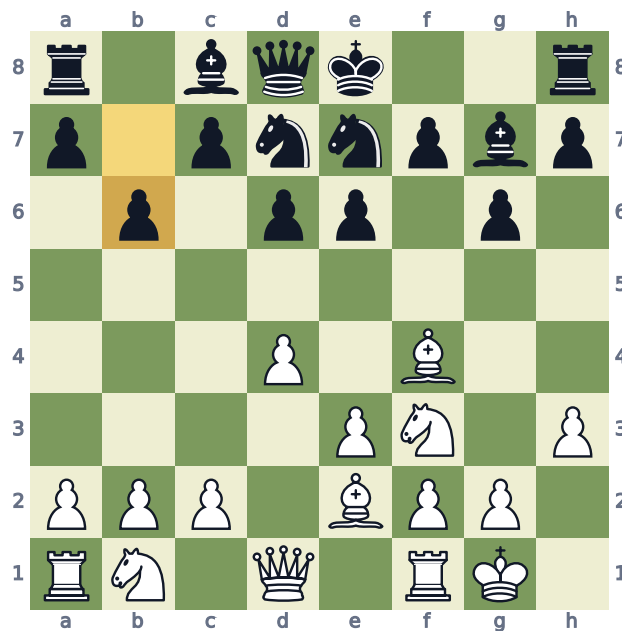
White may build e4 with Nbd2 and c3 if Black waits.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The London bishop is not the center; challenge d4 and e4.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.64 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. c4 O-O 2. Nc3 e5 3. dxe5 Nxe5 4. Nxe5 dxe5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

London System



YOUR TASK

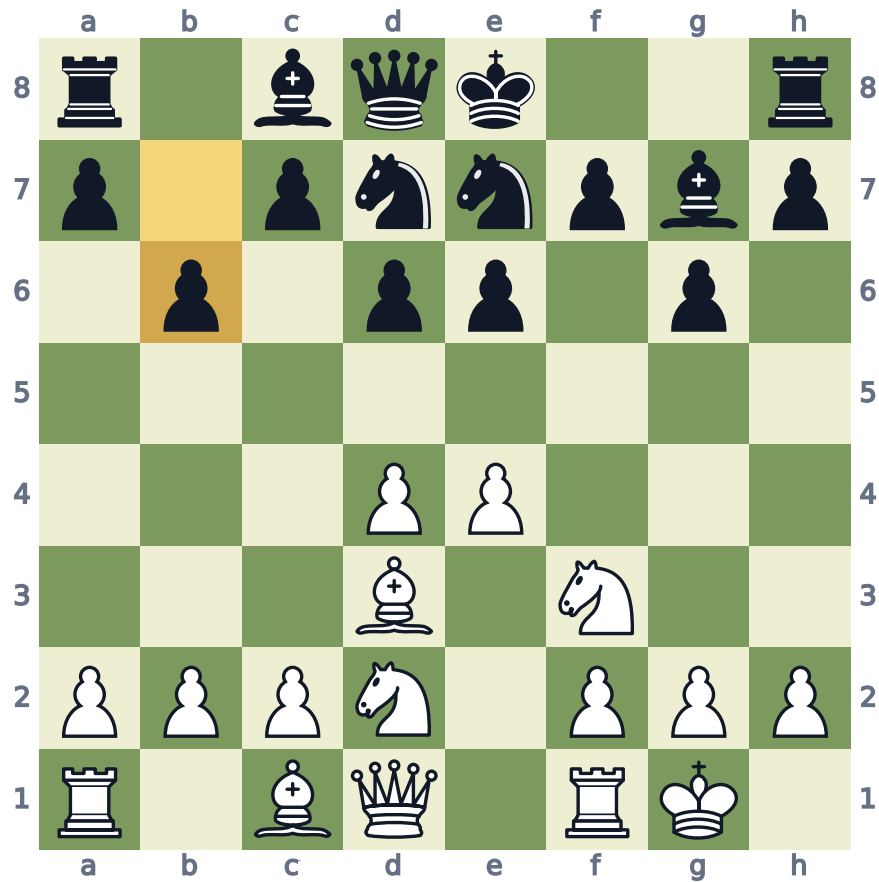
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

Colle System



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Bd3 e6 5. O-O Ne7 6. Nbd2 Nd7 7. e4 b6

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

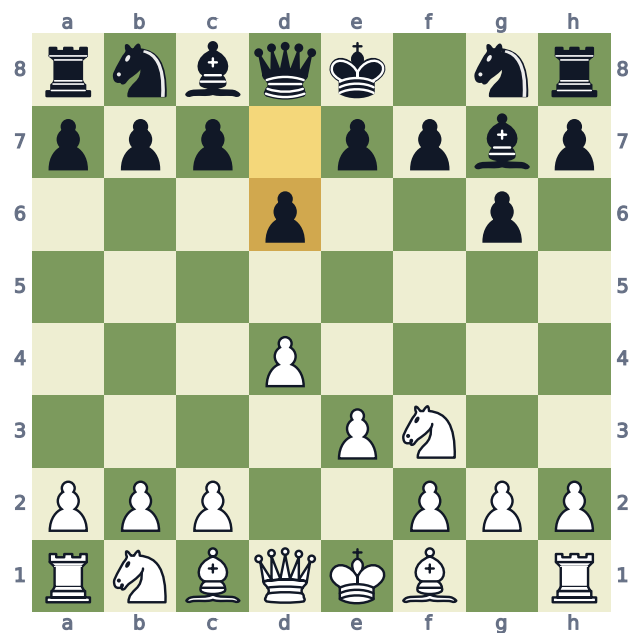
Use White's modest setup to complete development before central contact.

MAIN DANGER

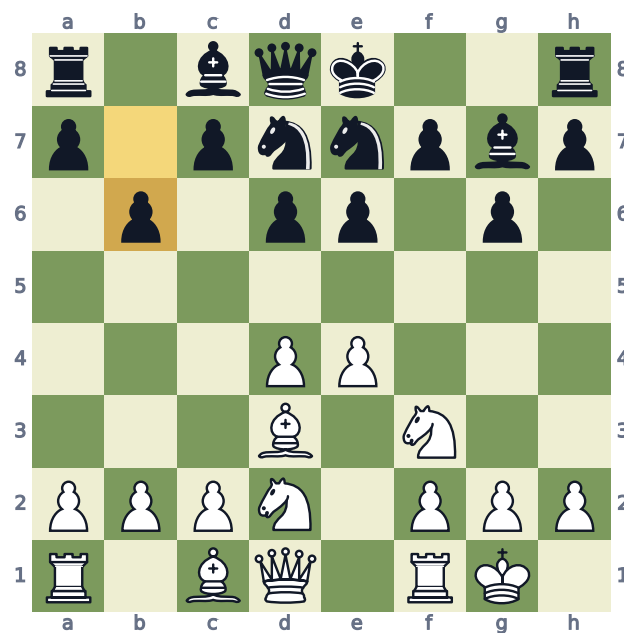
e5 can arrive with a strong kingside attack if Black remains passive.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Extra setup time is a resource only when it is invested in a break.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

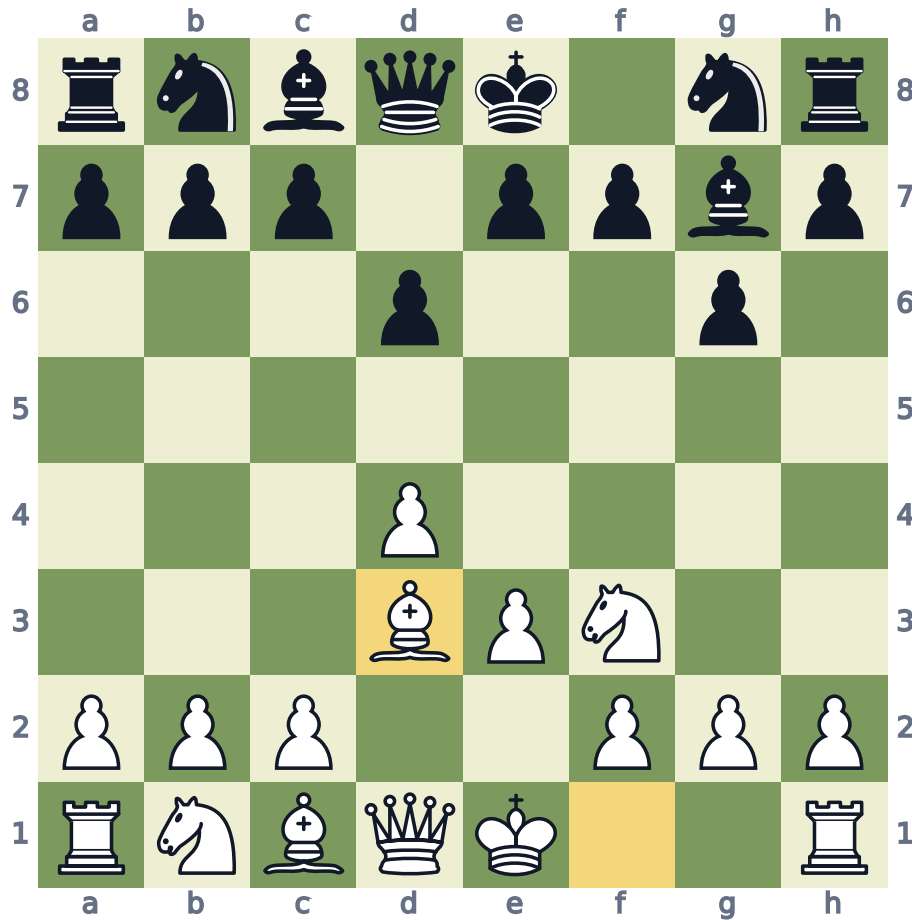
Position estimate: +0.74 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Re1 O-O 2. c3 c5 3. Nf1 cxd4 4. cxd4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

Colle System



YOUR TASK

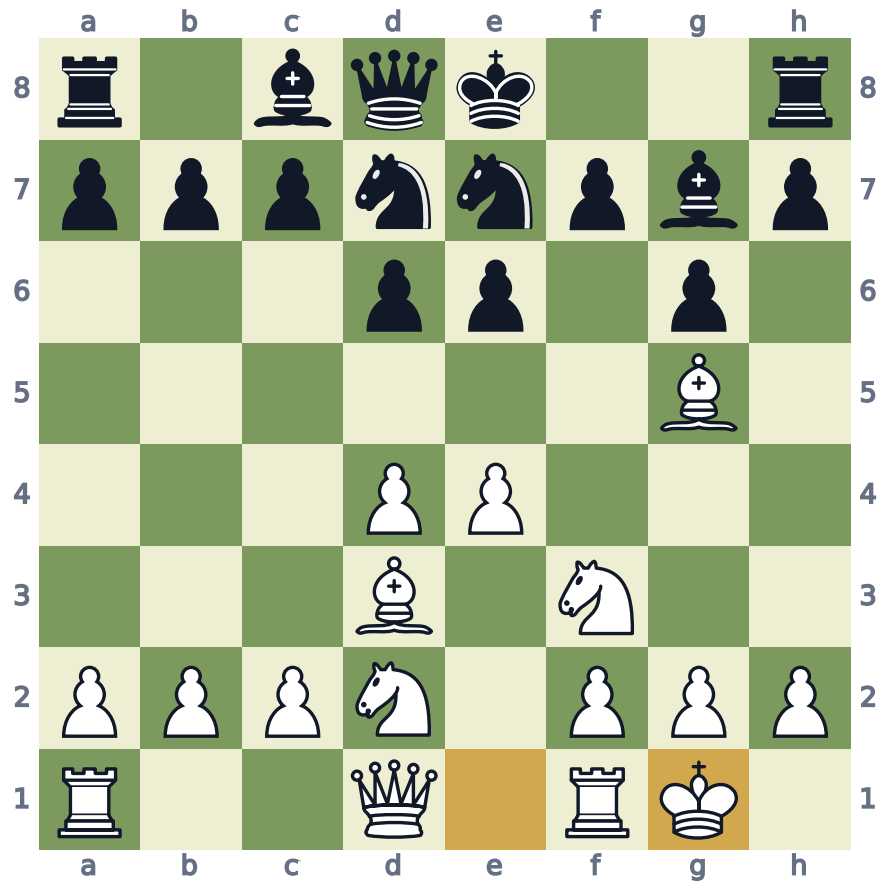
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

Torre bishop on g5



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. Bg5 d6 4. Nbd2 e6 5. e4 Ne7 6. Bd3 Nd7 7. O-O

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

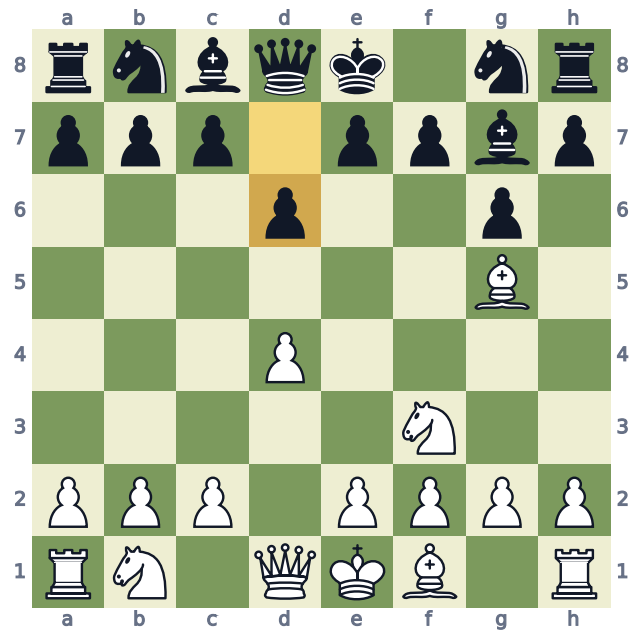
Build the shell while asking whether the bishop's pin has any concrete force.

MAIN DANGER

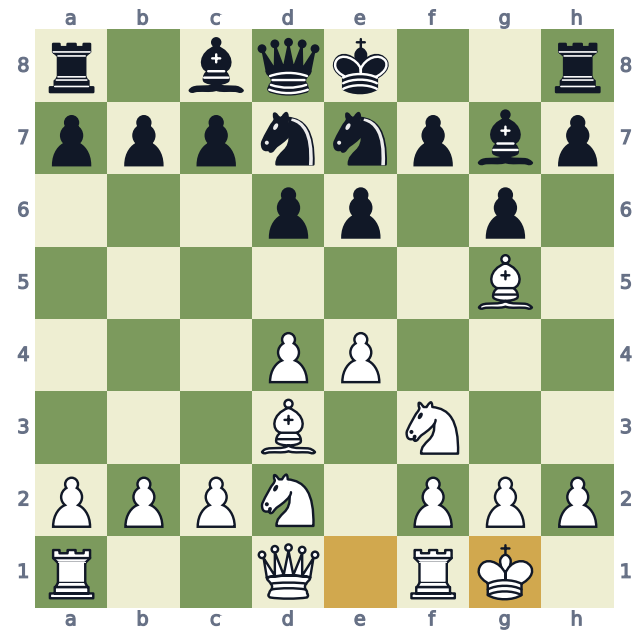
e5 can exploit the bishop's pressure and Black's cramped knights.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Do not spend time attacking Bg5 unless the gain helps the central break.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.64 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. O-O Re1 2. h6 Be3 3. f5 exf5 4. exf5 Nf1 5. b6 c3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

Torre bishop on g5



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

Jobava-style Nc3 and Bf4



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. Bf4 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Keep the king flexible and seek c5 against White's queenside castling plan.

MAIN DANGER

Nb5, h4, and e5 can create tactics before Black castles.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Nc3 plus long castling makes move order tactical; counter in the center and queenside.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

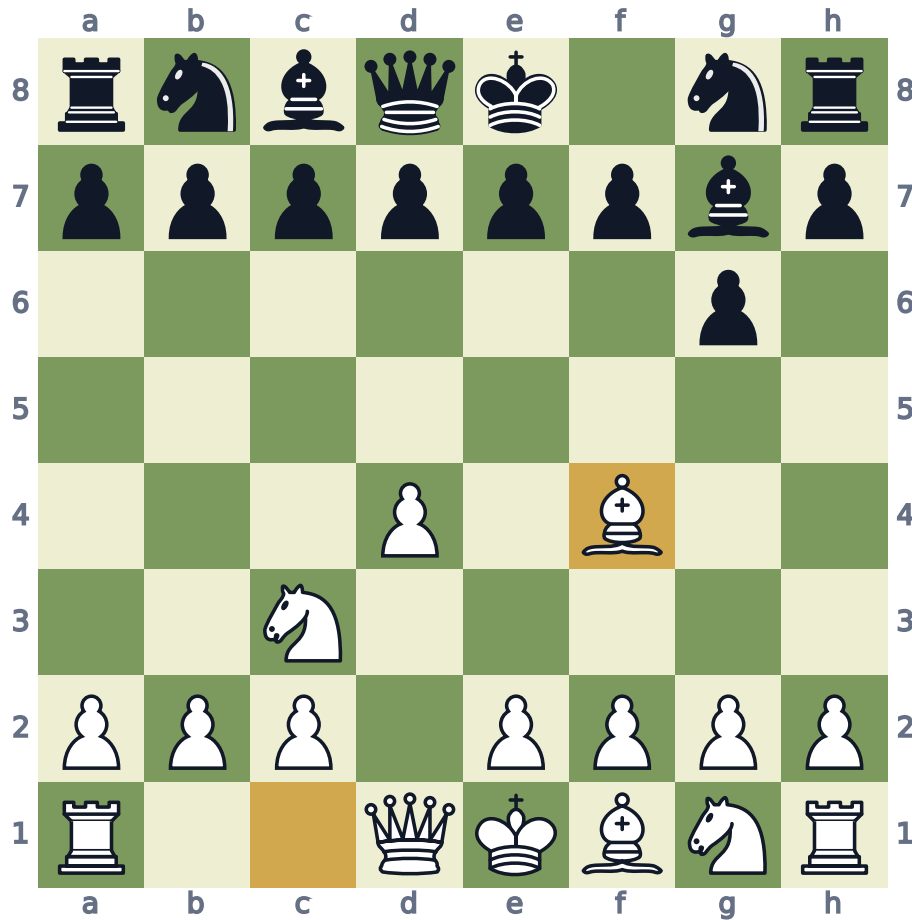
Position estimate: +1.27 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bh6 Bxh6 2. Qxh6 Ng8 3. Qf4 a6 4. e5 Qe7 5. Be2 d5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

Jobava-style Nc3 and Bf4



YOUR TASK

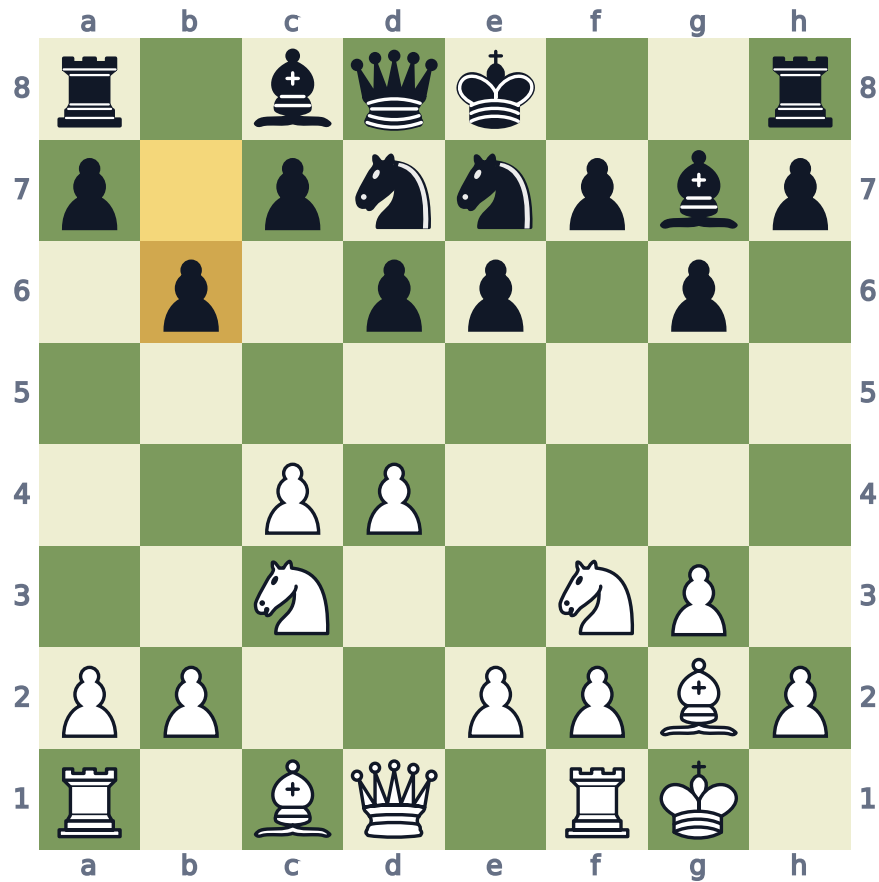
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

Catalan fianchetto



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nf3 d6 4. g3 e6 5. Bg2 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7 7. Nc3 b6

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Prepare Bb7 and central contact while respecting the long diagonal.

MAIN DANGER

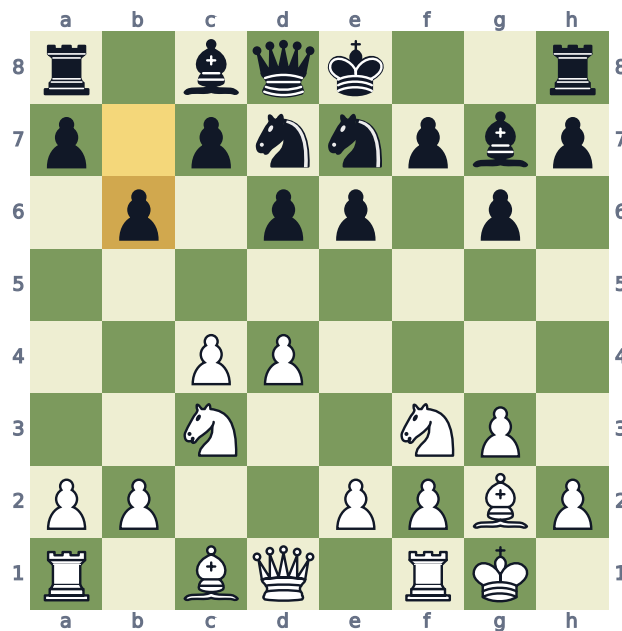
d5 or e4 can give White lasting space and pressure.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

In a double fianchetto, the pawn break decides which bishop is real.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

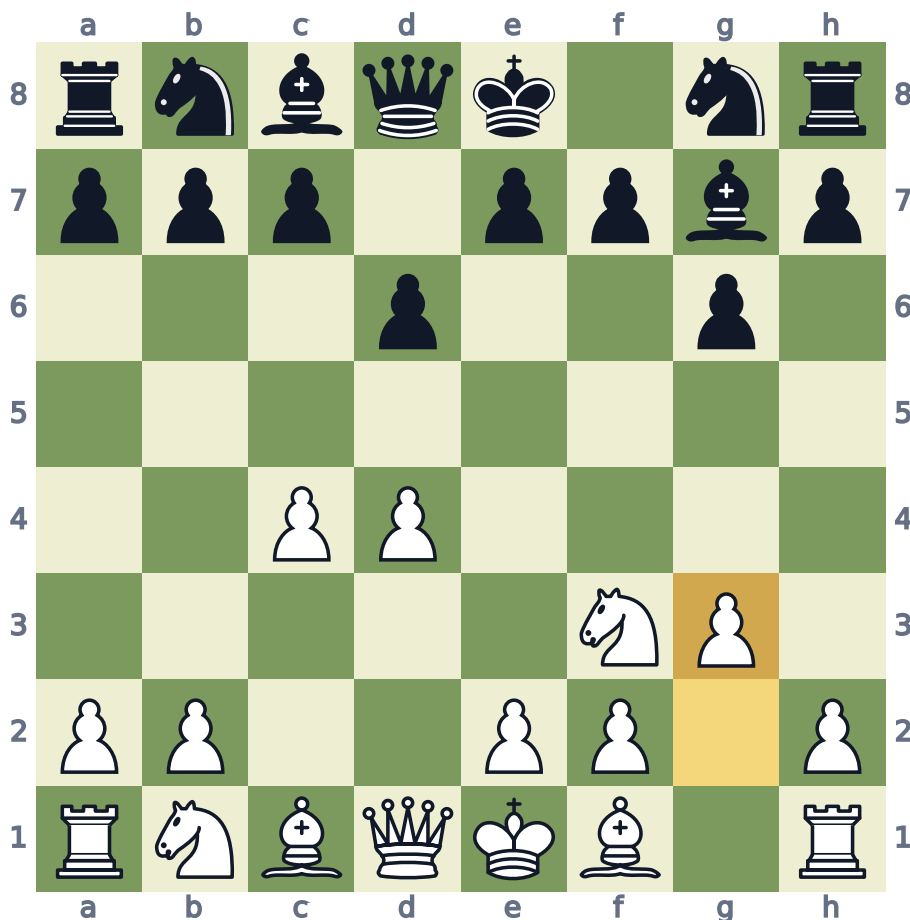
Position estimate: +0.93 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. e4 O-O 2. Be3 a6 3. Re1 Rb8 4. Rc1 c5 5. dxc5 Nxc5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

Catalan fianchetto



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

Trompowsky-style Bg5



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Bg5 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Nd2 e6 5. Ngf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 Nd7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

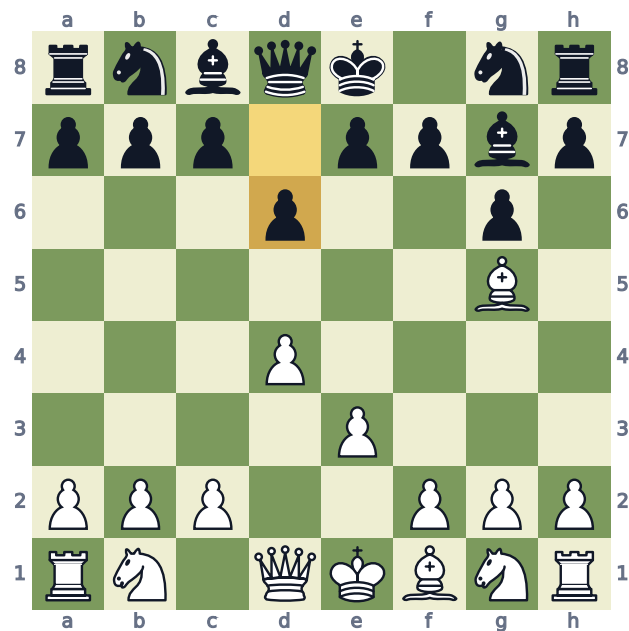
Complete development and prepare e5 before White establishes an unchallenged center.

MAIN DANGER

h4-h5 can combine with e4-e5 and a quick attack.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

White's e3 protects d4; now Black can build the shell without overlooking a loose pawn.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

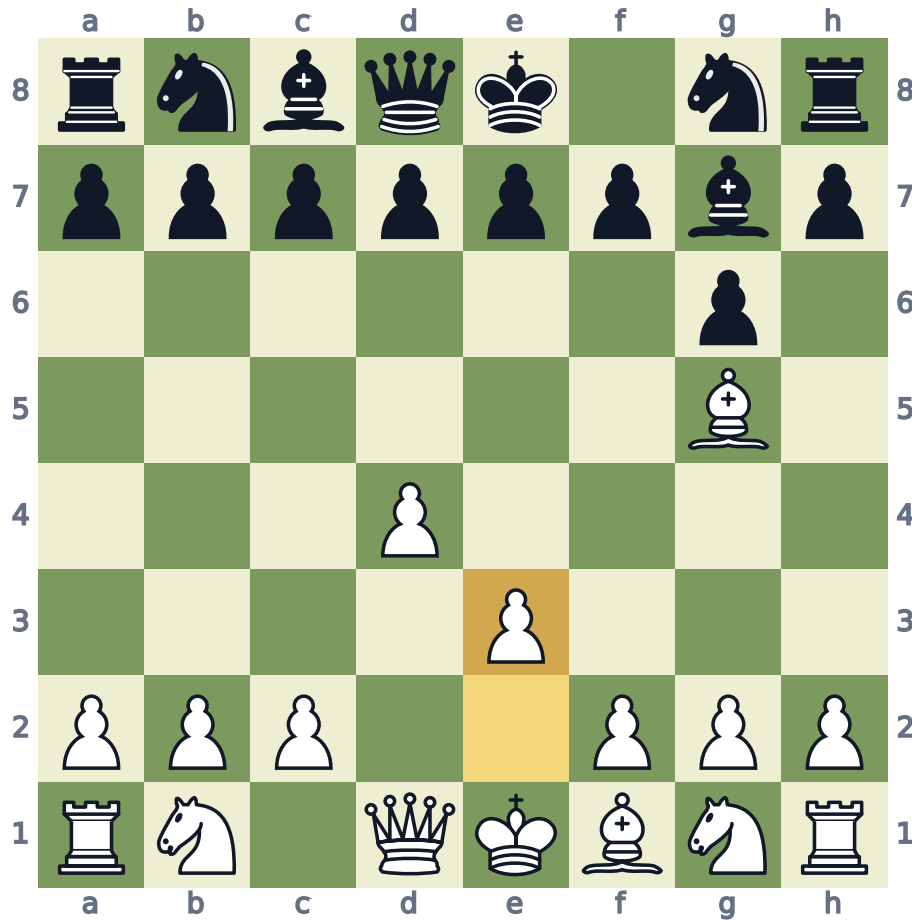
Position estimate: +0.12 for White (equal). Principal continuation: 1. Bh4 h6 2. c3 e5 3. h3 O-O 4. O-O f5 5. dxe5 dxe5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

Trompowsky-style Bg5



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

Stonewall formation



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. e3 Bg7 3. f4 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

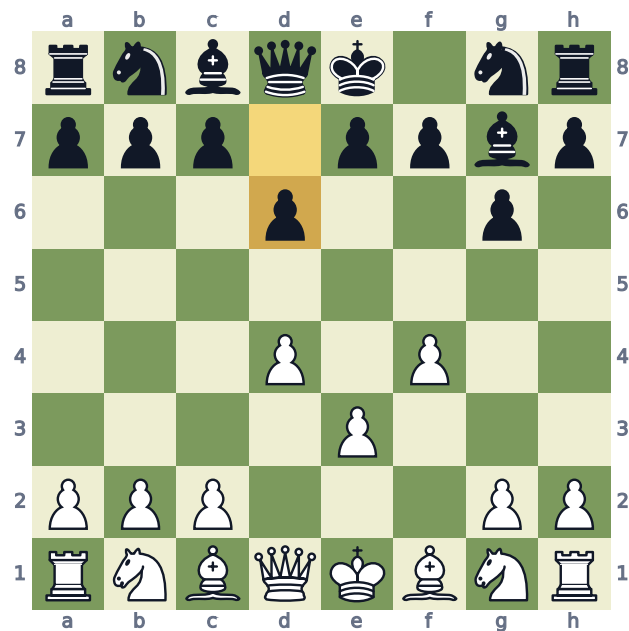
Target the dark-square holes and prepare e5 or c5 against the fixed chain.

MAIN DANGER

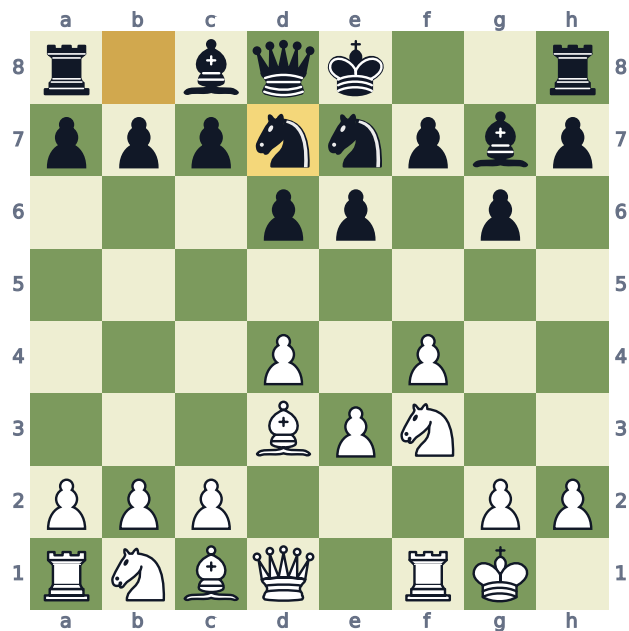
f5 and a kingside attack can arrive quickly.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The Stonewall gains space and permanently concedes e4; make that square useful.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

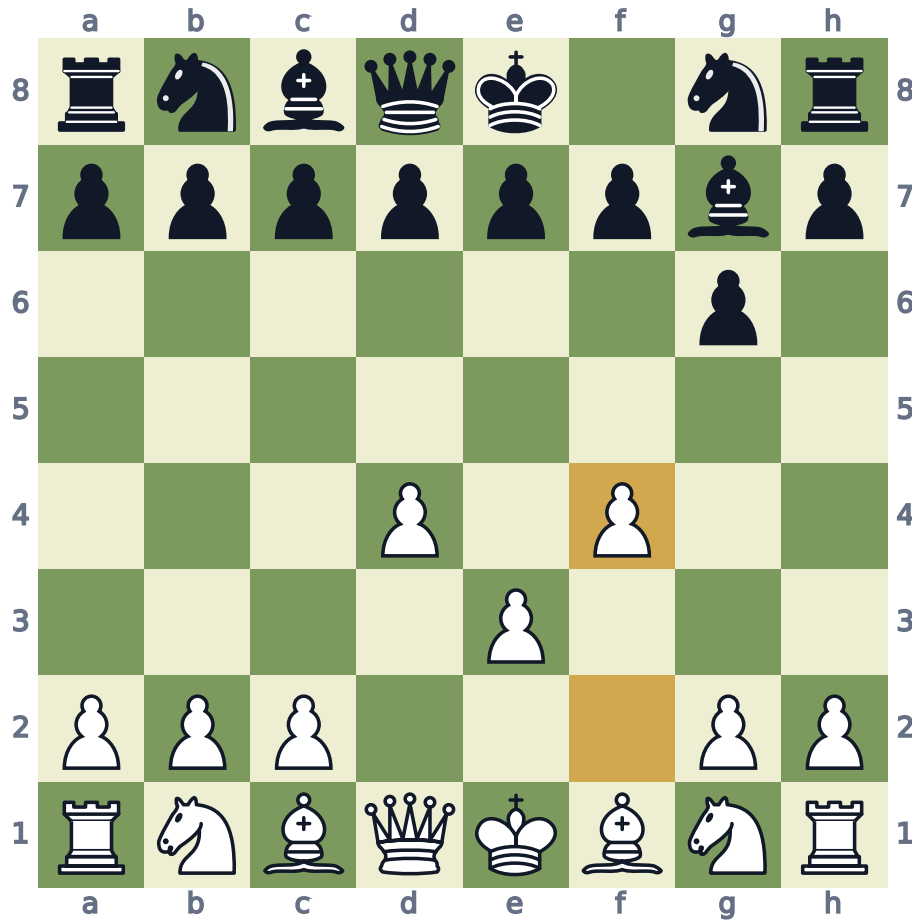
Position estimate: +0.34 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. e4 O-O 2. c3 c5 3. Be3 b6 4. Qe2 Bb7 5. a4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

Stonewall formation



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. CLASSICAL QUEEN'S PAWN CENTER

Course move: Ne7. Purpose: Complete the shell and prepare c5 or e5 against the broad center. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. b6 e5 4. dxe5 Nxe5 5. Nfd7 Bf3 (+0.88 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: d5 can gain space and restrict both knights.

02. LONDON SYSTEM

Course move: e6. Purpose: Develop without chasing Bf4 and prepare e5 or c5 against d4. Engine comparison: 1. c5 c3 2. cxd4 cxd4 3. Nf6 Nc3 4. Qb6 (+0.09 for White (equal)). Warning: White may build e4 with Nbd2 and c3 if Black waits.

03. COLLE SYSTEM

Course move: e6. Purpose: Use White's modest setup to complete development before central contact. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 e4 2. O-O h3 3. c5 c3 4. cxd4 (+0.30 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: e5 can arrive with a strong kingside attack if Black remains passive.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. TORRE BISHOP ON G5

Course move: d6. Purpose: Build the shell while asking whether the bishop's pin has any concrete force. Engine comparison: 1. h6 Bf4 2. c5 c3 3. Nf6 dxc5 4. O-O e3 5. b6 cxb6 (-0.08 for White (equal)). Warning: e5 can exploit the bishop's pressure and Black's cramped knights.

05. JOBAVA-STYLE NC3 AND BF4

Course move: d6. Purpose: Keep the king flexible and seek c5 against White's queenside castling plan. Engine comparison: 1. d5 Qd2 2. c5 dxc5 3. e5 Bg3 4. d4 (+0.19 for White (equal)). Warning: Nb5, h4, and e5 can create tactics before Black castles.

06. CATALAN FIANCHETTO

Course move: e6. Purpose: Prepare Bb7 and central contact while respecting the long diagonal. Engine comparison: 1. c5 dxc5 2. Qa5+ Bd2 3. Qxc5 Nc3 4. Nf6 Rc1 5. Nc6 b3 (+0.45 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 or e4 can give White lasting space and pressure.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. TROMPOWSKY-STYLE BG5

Course move: d6. Purpose: Complete development and prepare e5 before White establishes an unchallenged center. Engine comparison: 1. c5 Nf3 2. h6 Bh4 3. cxd4 exd4 4. Nf6 Bd3 (-0.08 for White (equal)). Warning: h4-h5 can combine with e4-e5 and a quick attack.

08. STONEWALL FORMATION

Course move: d6. Purpose: Target the dark-square holes and prepare e5 or c5 against the fixed chain. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Nf3 2. O-O Be2 3. c5 O-O 4. d5 c3 5. Qc7 Nbd2 (-0.41 for White (Black is slightly better)). Warning: f5 and a kingside attack can arrive quickly.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.